

Sweet Lies: How Cereal Marketing Reshaped Childhood and Consumer Habits in America

A Paper

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By

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The breakfast cereal industry in the United States was transformed by the impact of innovative marketing strategies following World War II. New economic and social drivers started to change the middle class, along with the emergence of color television as a mass medium. Cereal companies started targeting children as a primary consumer base by appealing to their taste buds through advertising, cartoons, promotional toys, and athlete sponsorships. They aimed to shape preferences and build brand loyalty from an early age, creating long-lasting habits. While the benefits of convenience for increasingly busy families were real, so was the health impact of the cereal industry's high sugar diet, along with ethical concerns about advertising tactics aimed at children. The argument here is that a balance must be struck between corporate marketing tactics and the long-term public good, especially when it comes to children.

The post-World War II economic boom changed American lifestyles and consumer expectations, and breakfast cereal companies took advantage of this shift in consumer preferences. Suburbia was not just about new homes; it represented a whole new way of thinking about family life, where efficiency and modernity were goals and aspirations. Cereal companies recognized the cultural shift and marketed their products as not just food but as symbols of modern family living. They targeted stay-at-home moms concerned about dividing their caregiving responsibilities with employment. As Michael Kideckel remarks, "Many consumers surely saw some truth, then, in Shredded Wheat's argument that women's emancipation came from a 'ready-cooked, cooked to serve' food, or in the Postum Cereal Company's claim that Grape-Nuts being 'ready to serve' led to a 'saving in time and exertion [that] is appreciated by the housewife.'"¹ This strategy was deceptive because it acknowledged that the roles of women in society were evolving while also making it clear that they were still primarily responsible for

¹ Michael Solomon Kideckel, "Fresh from the Factory: Breakfast Cereal, Natural Food, and the Marketing of Reform, 1890–1920" (doctoral thesis, Columbia University, 2018), [Page 195], Columbia Academic Commons.

providing for their families. The cereal industry's genius was to connect their products to broader post-war ideas of advancement, suggesting that the conventional way of making breakfast was backward—nearly un-American—in a nation speeding towards modernity and global leadership. The economic expansion and move to suburbia also meant an increasing desire for leisure time and growing disposable income. These were key factors in the popularity of cereal as American families could now afford these higher-priced packaged cereals, while justifying the time saved on making breakfast for free time or more productive economic activities.

The onset of color TV in 1954 changed how cereal was marketed by building a richer connection between consumers and brands, fundamentally transforming the advertising process. Unlike static print media, television brought moving pictures with color into people's living rooms with active messages, sensory appeals, and strong emotions. This technological change was a new way of dynamic advertising and allowed cereal companies to sidestep the thought of choices. As Marvin Goldberg states, "The results of Study A suggest that children's short-term snack and breakfast food preferences tend to reflect their exposure experience. When they viewed TV commercials for highly sugared foods, they opted for more of these."² Television advertisements utilized movements, sound, and narrative to connect cereals with positive emotions in a manner that print advertisements could not. The advertisements effectively demonstrated what it's like to consume cereal, featuring sounds like pouring, milk splashing, and smiling faces, which evoked strong responses from viewers. For example, Apple Jacks often had visual commercials with crunchy bites, swirling milk, and bursts of laughter that brought taste to life on screen.³ In addition, television advertisements offered a new type of flexibility, as

² Marvin E. Goldberg, Gerald J. Gorn, and Wendy Gibson, "TV Messages for Snack and Breakfast Foods: Do They Influence Children's Preferences?," *Journal of Consumer Research* 5, no. 2 (1978): [Page 77], JSTOR.

³ *Kelloggs Apple Jacks Cereal Commercial*, directed by TV Toy Memories, Youtube, 2010, https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=C2jLv6_0Fz8.

messages could be changed on the fly, allowing for dynamic testing and letting companies understand consumer behavior quicker by learning in the moment. This adaptive feature of television marketing created an immediate and huge return on investment for cereal companies, changing how they approached consumer engagement. “Galst and White (1976) report a high degree of correspondence between children's purchase influence attempts and the foods that are heavily advertised on TV. They provide strong correlational data linking children's purchase influence attempts in supermarkets,....to the amount of commercial television they watched at home.”⁴ This new trend changed how Americans connected with products, shifting from feature-driven decisions to emotional connections with brands. This would rule consumer culture for decades to come.

The cereal market also used television's increasing influence to employ ‘pester power’ – a marketing strategy that encouraged children to nag their parents into making purchases⁵ – to reshape family purchasing behavior, especially in regards to breakfast. Charles Atkin's 1978 supermarket research revealed that children became powerful purchasers despite having no money of their own. Atkins states, “In the only previous observational study of cereal decision-making involving parents and children, Wells and LoSciuto found that three-fifths of the children attempted to influence cereal selection. In more than half of these cases, the child was successful in obtaining the desired cereal.”⁶ This was not simply a passive reaction to shifts in family engagement – cereal companies actively leveraged this by taking advantage of how children perceived advertising. Several factors combined to make this strategy successful: television offered direct access to children without parental supervision; post-war prosperity had

⁴ Goldberg, Gorn, and Gibson, "TV Messages," [Page 73].

⁵ Meghan R. Longacre et al., "Child-targeted TV Advertising and Preschoolers' Consumption of High-sugar Breakfast Cereals," *Appetite* 108 (January 2017): [Page 299], <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.appet.2016.10.014>.

⁶ Charles K. Atkin, "Observation of Parent-Child Interaction in Supermarket Decision-Making," *Journal of Marketing* 42, no. 4 (1978): [Page 42], <https://doi.org/10.2307/1250084>.

generated more disposable income to cater to children's demands; and shifting family structures meant that shopping trips now included children who could make instant demands. The revolutionary element wasn't so much that children made purchasing decisions but that cereal marketers intentionally repositioned children as solo customers with valid decision-making power. This reflected a huge shift in marketing tactics—treating kids not as shielded family members but as business targets that could turn their natural desires for autonomy and freedom against their parents.

Cartoon mascots were also created to build an emotional connection between children and brands, turning simple recognition into genuine feelings of attachment that went above and beyond the product itself. Companies strategically designed playful, mischievous characters that appealed to children's natural inclinations of testing boundaries and breaking rules. Characters like Tony the Tiger and Trix Rabbit functioned as modern versions of traditional trickster figures, allowing children to experience safe forms of rebellion within parent-approved foods. Thomas Green remarks, "The trickster tale in Western scholarship has a number of characteristics relevant to the study of the marketing of breakfast cereals. First, the primary motivating force that drives the dramatic action of many trickster tales is the acquisition of something, sometimes a valued magical object, but frequently only the desire for food."⁷ This description shows how well cereal advertisers understood children's thought processes, developing characters that acted as fantasy friends instead of just commercials. The always-frustrated Trix Rabbit (never able to eat his own cereal)⁸ specifically enabled children to test boundaries without consequences. In the early to mid 1960's, these mascots evolved from simple drawings to full-fledged and unique

⁷ Thomas Green, "Tricksters and the Marketing of Breakfast Cereals," *The Journal of Popular Culture* 40, no. 1 (2007): [Page #], <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1540-5931.2007.00353.x>.

⁸ *Trix Rabbit 1970s Silly Rabbit Trix Are for Kids*, directed by TastySurrealBowl, Youtube, 2013, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Z3ApTwWRQNw>.

personalities with catchphrases and backstories; they formed intense emotional connections with kids beyond the product itself. “This serves to 'deposit' and cue an image of the product in the minds of children to prompt a visual memory of the product when the young consumer is in the presence of the packaged product on the shelf at the supermarket.”⁹ The most successful cereal mascots struck a careful balance: wholesome enough for parents’ approval while maintaining enough of a playful side to captivate children. This strategy of connecting through storytelling rather than product features created deeper consumer connections that often lasted into adulthood, with many grown consumers keeping nostalgic attachments to their childhood cereals.

The use of in-box premiums (prizes inside a cereal box) and collectibles was another strategy that proved remarkably effective at influencing children’s cereal preferences. Joseph Miller and Paul Busch’s experimental studies discovered that premium commercials could alter children’s pre-established taste preferences. This insight led cereal companies to shift focus toward developing more captivating in-box promotions, sometimes at the cost of promoting the actual food product. “On a typical Saturday morning, a child will see no ad for fruit, vegetables, cheese, eggs, or other valuable nutritional foods, but instead will be cajoled into buying new sugar cereal with a toy premium or to put syrup in his milk to make it fun.”¹⁰ The strategy leveraged a child’s natural instincts to “collect”, encouraging repeat purchases to complete sets or acquire new toys. By blending play and food, cereal companies transformed breakfast into an entire experience combined with entertainment, further strengthening kids’ ‘pester power’ as children requested specific cereals just for the included premiums instead of the taste. “It was

⁹ Randy Page et al., "Targeting Children in the Cereal Aisle," *American Journal of Health Education* 39, no. 5 (2008): [Page 276], <https://doi.org/10.1080/19325037.2008.10599050>.

¹⁰ Elaine S. Reiss, "Special Problems in Advertising," *Food, Drug, Cosmetic Law Journal* 31, no. 5 (1976): [Page 253], JSTOR.

common for cereal boxes to offer activities to engage children. The most common was offering interesting facts or trivia (55.7%) and solving activities (50.0%), such as puzzles, word games, word searches, matching activities, finding activities, mazes, brainteasers, quizzes, and riddles. Acquisition of the answers to solving activities required a product purchase on 18.9% of the packages...”¹¹ This desire for a ‘premium experience’ fundamentally changed family purchasing decisions, creating a situation where children’s desire for toys and collectibles directly influenced grocery shopping behavior.

While cartoon mascots appealed to children’s imagination, cereal brands simultaneously employed athlete endorsements and sponsorships to associate their products with sports success, creating a ‘dual’ marketing approach. This strategy became particularly effective as television made sports viewing an increasingly popular national pastime after the war. Maria Veri states, “...advertisers explicitly targeted children raised on cereal by stressing how cereal consumption provided the energy needed for a productive day of work or study. Wheaties continued this line of advertising with its use of famous and successful athletes on its cereal boxes and in print advertisements for its ‘Breakfast of Champions’ campaign.”¹² Veri’s research shows how the Wheaties’ campaign started a powerful idea, suggesting that athletic success begins at breakfast. This timing was perfect, coinciding with the rapid growth of professional sports leagues and, accordingly, an increase in television viewership. As suburban families acquired televisions, they encountered both sports programming and cereal commercials, creating an unconscious connection that cereal producers expertly exploited. The genius of this approach was its ability to satisfy the needs of different family members, and children could imagine becoming their sports

¹¹ Page et al., "Targeting Children," [Page 274].

¹² Maria J. Veri, "Got Athletes? The Use of Male Athlete Celebrity Endorsers in Early Twentieth-Century Dairy-Industry Promotions," *Journal of Sport History* 43, no. 3 (2016): [Page 300], <https://doi.org/10.5406/jsporthistory.43.3.0290>.

heroes. At the same time, parents believed they were supporting their children's physical development. Unlike cartoon characters and mascots, athlete endorsements achieved something important: they made sugar-heavy cereals appear healthy and performance-enhancing, effectively hiding their nutritional content behind ideas of fitness and athletic achievement. This cross-generational appeal became increasingly valuable as media options expanded in the 1970s, helping cereal manufacturers maintain relevance as children's entertainment options multiplied.

By the early 1970s, though, growing concerns about sugar in children's cereal had begun to challenge the industry's carefully constructed image, marking the start of a significant shift in how parents and regulators viewed these products. "Nutritionists scream that cereal firms corrupt young minds by telling them that 'sugar coated junkies' are good for them, and that they are undermining the American diet by promoting the sale of convenience foods which are lower in nutritional value than other cheaper, basic food commodities."¹³ Theresa Flaim's 1972 research was among the first serious attempts to weigh the benefits and harms of heavily sugary cereals. Her work showed that while quick breakfasts helped busy families save time, many popular children's cereals— some containing up to 50% sugar¹⁴— raised health concerns that would only grow stronger in later years. This criticism emerged as doctors and nutritionists started connecting sugar to childhood cavities, weight gain, and hyperactivity, putting cereal makers on the defensive for the first time. The industry first tried to focus on convenience while downplaying nutrition concerns, but as Flaim documents, this approach became harder to sustain as medical evidence piled up. Health advocates began pushing for advertising limits similar to tobacco regulations, arguing that marketing sugary products to children under the label of a

¹³ Theresa Flaim, "Public Regulation of the Cereal Industry: The Need to Change National Policy regarding Consumer Protection," *Journal of the Northeastern Agricultural Economics Council* 1 (October 1972): [Page 271], <https://doi.org/10.1017/s016354840000039x>.

¹⁴ B.W LI and P. J. Schuhmann, "GAS-LIQUID CHROMATOGRAPHIC ANALYSIS of 'SUGARS in READY-TO-EAT BREAKFAST CEREALS,'" *Journal of Food Science* 45, no. 1 (1980): [Page 138], <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1365-2621.1980.tb03889.x>.

‘nutritious breakfast’ was misleading. The link to fitness and athletic achievement also started to be questioned. As Flaim noted, “....Other advertisements attribute athletic performance to consumption of particular ready-to-eat cereals when in reality the product has almost nothing to do with such performance.”¹⁵

By the late 1970s, the federal government also began questioning the unchecked influence that cereal advertising had on children, marking a crucial turning point in the public’s understanding of marketing ethics. The Federal Trade Commission (FTC) accused cereal companies of not only manipulating kids but also distorting the market itself, and “that the heavy advertising expenditures blocked entry and that the advertising appeals used were unfair, especially to children.”¹⁶ Scott Bruce and Bill Crawford exemplified this through a particularly telling statistic: “In 1993, more than 1.3 million advertisements for cereal aired on American television, or more than twenty-five hours of cereal advertising per day... Only auto manufacturers spent more money on television advertising than the makers of breakfast cereal.”¹⁷ The FTC recognized that the heavy bombardment of such ads wasn’t just persuasive– it was designed to override children’s ability to critically evaluate the products, exploiting their developmental vulnerability. This wasn’t just about selling cereal; it was about getting consumers emotionally attached to brands before they could fully understand what branding meant and the effect it had on them. The FTC’s intervention signaled the start of a broader public health debate: at what point does marketing stop becoming persuasive and start becoming predatory? Although the FTC’s efforts were ultimately defeated by industry pressure, their brief campaign revealed how the economic success of the cereal industry was built on psychological tactics directed at

¹⁵ Flaim, "Public Regulation," [Page 271].

¹⁶ Brian Francis Harris, "Shared Monopoly and Antitrust Policy : an Empirical Investigation of the Effects of the FTC's Restructuring Proposals for the Cereal Industry" (doctoral thesis, Michigan State University, 1978), [Page 5], MSU Libraries Digital Repository.

¹⁷ Scott Bruce and Bill Crawford, *Cerealizing America : the Unsweetened Story of American Breakfast Cereal* (Boston: Faber and Faber, 1995), [Page 18], <https://archive.org/details/cerealizingameri00scot/page/n17/mode/2up>.

children who couldn't avoid them. The FTC's concerns appear valid and prophetic when paired with long-term health studies showing that children exposed to these ads were more likely to prefer— and overconsume— high-sugar cereals.¹⁸ This moment in history exposes how corporate marketing strategies can often outpace public protections, raising serious questions about the balance between business freedom and the civic responsibility to safeguard vulnerable populations such as children.

This pressure eventually forced companies to adapt. By the 1980's Kellogg's and others began highlighting the health benefits of their products, such as fiber content. As Pauline Ippolito and Alan Mathios found, "The evidence on new product developments suggests that health claims are a significant factor in stimulating the development and successful introduction of more nutritious products in the market."¹⁹ Their research showed that producer health claims led to a significant rise in consumer awareness about nutrition, suggesting that market forces sometimes work better than government campaigns in changing eating habits. This shift from unquestioned, sugar-filled cereal products to more health-conscious options shows how criticism of the sugar content in cereal led to significant changes in food marketing rules and consumer expectations on nutritional information. The cereal industry's journey through this period shows how even popular products can shift from being widely accepted to being closely scrutinized as societal values change.

The evolution of breakfast cereal— from a post-war convenience food to a cultural phenomenon to a more health-conscious selection of choices— shows the balance between corporate strategy and consumer demand, influenced by public discourse. As America moved into the fast-paced, 'hustle' culture of the 21st century, cereal's main advantage— being quick and

¹⁸ Longacre et al., "Child-targeted TV Advertising," [Page 298].

¹⁹ Pauline M. Ippolito and Alan D. Mathios, "Health Claims in Food Marketing: Evidence on Knowledge and Behavior in the Cereal Market," *Journal of Public Policy and Marketing* 10, no. 1 (1991): [Page 25], JSTOR.

easy—made it a perfect fit for a society that valued productivity and fun more than tradition. The fact that “Forty-nine percent of Americans start each morning with a bowl of cereal”²⁰, more than any other single food or beverage item, even coffee, which came in at twenty-eight percent in the poll, means more than just market success. It shows how the very idea of an all-American breakfast was completely redefined. This shift wasn’t just about changing taste— it changed how households functioned, morning routines, and even the idea of a family ‘on-the-go’. However, as nutrition science advanced, it created a growing conflict between what made consumers happy in the short term and what was good for public health in the long term. It also demonstrated that some supervision is necessary to protect vulnerable groups, especially children, from being taken advantage of by companies. As such, the question isn’t whether cereal companies or even breakfast cereal itself is good or bad, but rather how you find balance. The eventual shift toward healthier cereals wasn’t just a business move but also a result of public pressure and government regulation, which are important for keeping mature markets in check. As breakfast cereal enters its second century in American kitchens, its lasting popularity shows that convenience still matters most. However, the changes in how cereals are made show that convenience can’t come at any cost. This shift isn’t a failure of the market, but a correction— a needed move away from unchecked capitalism towards a more fair balance between what businesses want and what the public needs.

²⁰ Bruce and Crawford, *Cerealizing America*, [Page 18].

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